

D657

Design Applied Learning Capstone

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

Six weeks into a capstone redesign of a food bank's volunteer sign-up flow, the director, who has led the organization for 15 years, asks the student team to also redesign the donor portal. The agreed brief covers only volunteer sign-up, and eight weeks remain. What is the best response?

- A. Refuse any discussion, because the brief is final.
- B. Agree because of the director's long tenure.
- C. Add the donor portal quietly and work extra hours.
- D. Acknowledge the need, explain its impact on the agreed timeline and deliverables, and agree together whether to trade scope or log it for later.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

At the end of a project, the client says the work "missed the point," and the team says it delivered what was asked. What step, done at the start, would most likely have prevented this?

- A. Writing down and agreeing on the problem and success measures with the client.
- B. Making more high-fidelity screens.
- C. Picking a better color palette.
- D. Presenting only at the end to save the client's time.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A teammate on a four-person capstone team presented a prototype in which the "Submit" button sits below the fold on phones. She designed it on a large studio monitor. Which feedback is most useful?

- A. "On a phone, Submit is below the fold, so users may not see how to finish; could it sit higher or stay fixed?"
- B. "You should stop using a big monitor."
- C. "This is careless."
- D. "Nice work overall!"

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

After a review, the client’s marketing VP wants a bigger logo on every page, while test data shows 3 of 5 users missed the main call to action. The VP signs the invoices. With one iteration left, what should the team prioritize?

- A. The logo change, since the VP signs the invoices.
- B. Neither, because feedback should never change a finished design.
- C. Fixing the missed call to action, and explaining to the VP how that serves the shared goal.
- D. Both at once, with equal effort.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A designer applied all 40 comments from a review, and the design became cluttered and inconsistent. What went wrong?

- A. Reviews should include no more than 10 comments.
- B. The designer did not sort and prioritize feedback against user needs and goals.
- C. Feedback should be ignored after the first round.
- D. The designer received too little feedback.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

At a zoo’s membership project, the operations lead wants a one-page sign-up form, and the fundraising lead wants a three-step form with donation prompts. Both joined the zoo the same year. No user data exists yet. What should the designer do?

- A. Always choose the shortest form.
- B. Pick whichever lead is more senior.
- C. Restate the shared goal and run a quick test of both versions with members.
- D. Build a two-step form as a compromise.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A capstone team learns in week two that the client has no analytics and cannot say who its users are. The final presentation is in nine weeks, and the client's office is being remodeled. What is the best next step?

- A. Pause until the client installs analytics.
- B. Build the full design on the team's best guesses.
- C. Wait until the remodel is done.
- D. List working assumptions about users and run quick interviews or a short survey to test them.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A graduate's portfolio has twelve polished app screens set on a sleek black background, with no text. She was the research lead on a five-person team. A hiring manager says she can't tell what the candidate did. What is the best improvement?

- A. Change to a white background.
- B. Add more screens.
- C. Present all the work as solely hers.
- D. Add a case study stating the problem, her research-lead role, key decisions, and the outcome.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A hiring manager reads a case study and asks, "What changed because of your work?" Which part of the case study is missing?

- A. The designer's tool list.
- B. The problem statement.
- C. The outcome, such as results measured against the goal.
- D. Nothing; outcomes are never expected from students.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

In capstone ideation calls, two remote members on slow internet and one new member rarely speak, while two senior members, who both studied abroad, fill most of the time. What change best supports inclusive collaboration?

- A.** Drop the remote members from calls.
- B.** Start with silent idea writing in a shared board, then have each member share in turn.
- C.** Let the seniors lead because they have more experience.
- D.** Require everyone to speak for exactly five minutes.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

After the capstone redesign, a clinic's online appointment completion rate rose from 60% to 78%. The new design used a softer color palette and took 300 hours. How should the team report the change?

- A.** 300 hours of design delivered.
- B.** An 18-percentage-point increase, which is a 30% relative improvement.
- C.** An 18% improvement.
- D.** A 23% improvement.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A redesign improved a sign-up rate by 25% relative to a 40% baseline. What is the new sign-up rate?

- A.** 50%
- B.** 65%
- C.** 25%
- D.** 30%

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

Six weeks into a capstone redesign of a food bank's volunteer sign-up flow, the director, ~~who has led the organization for 15 years~~, asks the student team to also redesign the donor portal. The agreed brief covers only volunteer sign-up, and eight weeks remain. What is the best response?

Target word: handling a scope request **Decides:** The request is outside the agreed scope.

A	Absolute language	Scope can change, but through a deliberate trade-off.
B	Camouflage	Tenure does not change the scope agreement.
C	Inverted operation	Silent scope creep endangers the original deliverable.
D	Correct	Scope changes are decided openly against the original agreement.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

At the end of a project, the client says the work “missed the point,” and the team says it delivered what was asked. What step, done at the start, would most likely have prevented this?

Target word: reverse from outcome to missing step **Decides:** Shared success criteria at kickoff.

A	Correct	Shared criteria give both sides the same definition of done.
B	Adjacent category	More output does not fix a misaligned target.
C	Confusion set	Visuals are not the gap.
D	Inverted operation	Fewer check-ins makes misalignment worse.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A teammate on a four-person capstone team presented a prototype in which the “Submit” button sits below the fold on phones. ~~She designed it on a large studio monitor~~. Which feedback is most useful?

Target word: actionable feedback **Decides:** Specific situation, behavior, impact.

A	Correct	Names the situation, the design choice, and its effect.
B	Camouflage	Targets the setup, not the design issue.
C	Inverted operation	Judges the person rather than describing the work.
D	Dropped element	No specifics to act on.

4. Answer C Concept 3

After a review, the client's marketing VP wants a bigger logo on every page, while test data shows 3 of 5 users missed the main call to action. ~~The VP signs the invoices~~. With one iteration left, what should the team prioritize?

Target word: prioritizing feedback **Decides:** User evidence tied to the goal outranks rank.

A	Camouflage	Who pays does not change user evidence.
B	Absolute language	Iteration exists to use feedback.
C	Correct	Evidence of a task failure outranks a preference.
D	Dropped element	Skips prioritization with limited time.

5. Answer B Concept 3 · transfer

A designer applied all 40 comments from a review, and the design became cluttered and inconsistent. What went wrong?

Target word: diagnose over-incorporation **Decides:** Feedback was not filtered by goals.

A	Wrong stem number	The count is not the rule.
B	Correct	Feedback must be weighed, not applied wholesale.
C	Absolute language	Overcorrects in the other direction.
D	Inverted operation	The problem was too much unfiltered input.

6. Answer C Concept 4

At a zoo's membership project, the operations lead wants a one-page sign-up form, and the fundraising lead wants a three-step form with donation prompts. ~~Both joined the zoo the same year.~~ No user data exists yet. What should the designer do?

Target word: resolve stakeholder conflict **Decides:** Return to the goal and gather evidence.

A	Absolute language	A rule of thumb, not evidence for this case.
B	Camouflage	Seniority does not decide design.
C	Correct	Evidence settles the disagreement better than opinion.
D	Adjacent category	Splitting the difference may satisfy no one and serves no evidence.

7. Answer D Concept 5

A capstone team learns in week two that the client has no analytics and cannot say who its users are. The final presentation is in nine weeks, ~~and the client's office is being remodeled.~~ What is the best next step?

Target word: acting within ambiguity **Decides:** Name assumptions and run a small test to reduce uncertainty.

A	Inverted operation	Waiting for certainty burns the timeline.
B	Dropped element	Skips testing the assumptions.
C	Camouflage	The remodel does not block research.
D	Correct	The smallest step that reduces the biggest unknown.

8. Answer D Concept 6

A graduate's portfolio has twelve polished app screens ~~set on a sleek black background,~~ with no text. She was the research lead on a five-person team. A hiring manager says she can't tell what the candidate did. What is the best improvement?

Target word: what a case study needs **Decides:** Problem, role, process, outcome.

A	Camouflage	Styling does not explain her contribution.
B	Dropped element	More visuals without context repeat the problem.
C	Inverted operation	Misrepresents team work and her actual role.
D	Correct	Hiring managers judge process and role, not only visuals.

9. Answer C Concept 6 · transfer

A hiring manager reads a case study and asks, “What changed because of your work?” Which part of the case study is missing?

Target word: identify the missing section **Decides:** The outcome/impact section.

A	Adjacent category	Tools are not outcomes.
B	Confusion set	Explains why work started, not what changed.
C	Correct	Impact answers “what changed.”
D	Absolute language	Even student work can show measured results.

10. Answer B Concept 7

In capstone ideation calls, two remote members on slow internet and one new member rarely speak, while two senior members, ~~who both studied abroad~~, fill most of the time. What change best supports inclusive collaboration?

Target word: structure for inclusion **Decides:** Silent writing and rotation give all voices a turn.

A	Adjacent category	Excludes rather than includes.
B	Correct	Structure lets quieter and remote members contribute equally.
C	Inverted operation	Keeps the imbalance.
D	Absolute language	Rigid time rules don’t address how ideas are gathered.

11. Answer B Concept 8

After the capstone redesign, a clinic’s online appointment completion rate rose from 60% to 78%. ~~The new design used a softer color palette and took 300 hours.~~ How should the team report the change?

Target word: report change correctly **Decides:** $78 - 60 = 18$ points; $18/60 = 30\%$ relative.

A	Camouflage	An output, not an outcome.
B	Correct	18 points; $18 / 60 = 0.30$.
C	Confusion set	Mixes percentage points with percent change.
D	Inverted operation	$18 / 78$ uses the new rate as the base.

12. Answer A Concept 8 · transfer

A redesign improved a sign-up rate by 25% relative to a 40% baseline. What is the new sign-up rate?

Target word: solve for new rate **Decides:** $40\% \times 1.25$.

A	Correct	$40\% \times 1.25 = 50\%$.
B	Confusion set	Adds 25 percentage points instead of 25%.
C	Wrong stem number	The change, not the new rate.
D	Inverted operation	Applies a decrease.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	2	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	4	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	9	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	4	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Agree on scope and success criteria early	A client design project starts with an agreed problem, deliverables, and success measures; new requests are weighed against that scope, not absorbed silently.	Saying yes to every added request to keep the client happy (scope creep).	A mid-project request that was not in the original brief.
2	Giving actionable feedback	Useful feedback describes the specific situation, the observed behavior or design choice, and its impact.	Vague praise or blame ("It's great," "You're careless").	A choice among comments where only one names a specific instance and effect.
3	Incorporating feedback against goals	Feedback is sorted and prioritized by how it serves user needs and project goals, not by who said it.	Applying every comment, or the most senior person's comments first.	Conflicting feedback from people of different rank.
4	Resolving stakeholder conflict with evidence	When stakeholders disagree, return to the shared goal and user evidence, and test if evidence is lacking.	Splitting the difference or deferring to the loudest voice.	Two stakeholders want opposite designs.
5	Planning within ambiguity	In unclear situations, state assumptions, pick the smallest step that will reduce uncertainty, and revisit the plan as facts arrive.	Waiting for complete information before acting, or building a full plan on untested guesses.	Missing data, a deadline, and no clear owner of the answer.
6	Portfolio case studies show process and role	A strong case study states the problem, your specific role, the process and decisions, and the outcome, not only polished final screens.	A gallery of final visuals with no context, or claiming team work as solely your own.	A hiring manager asking "What did you do?"
7	Inclusive collaboration	Structure sessions so all voices contribute, such as silent idea writing before discussion and rotating who speaks first.	Open discussion where the most confident or senior people dominate.	Quiet or remote members rarely contribute.
8	Measuring design outcomes	Report results against a baseline using a metric tied to the goal, and be clear whether change is in percentage points or percent.	Mixing up percentage-point change and percent change, or reporting outputs (screens made) as outcomes.	Before and after rates in the same stem.

Course scope (public description): Design Applied Learning Capstone provides students with real-world applications to prepare them for the product and experience design industry. In this course, students will integrate and apply skills gained throughout the program by working with an organization on a design project. The capstone lets students apply their visual and technical design knowledge while also reinforcing the power skills of giving, receiving, and incorporating feedback, empathy and inclusive collaboration, planning within ambiguous situations, and navigating a complex problem. Further, students will refine their portfolios and personal brand to enhance their marketability and strategically plan for their future career.